SPLITTING HEIRS

The divorce drama of Kunda strongman **Raghuraj Pratap Singh** aka 'Raja Bhaiya' has spilled from courtrooms to social media. Estranged wife Bhanvi, who's long accused the MLA of abuse and affairs, recently posted videos of his 'arms cache'. Son Shivraj, defending the father, then called out his mother as a "jhootebaaz (liar)", even accusing her of assaulting his grandmother. Soon after, daughter Raghvi joined the action, but siding with her mother. With the kids also now picking sides, it's the TV channels that are having a field day.

SNUB SIGNALS

It's election time, and even ghosted calls count as political bombshells. Suspended RJD leader and Lalu's son **Tej Pratap Yadav** claims that repeated calls to Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav during the Voter Adhikar Yatra went unanswered, so he blocked the latter's number. The spat has a touch of farce: Tej Pratap's sister is married into Akhilesh's family. But then, in politics, a dropped call speaks louder than a thousand words.

NEW ICON IN TOWN

From Garba nights in Surat and Visavadar to his debut assembly session in September, AAP's Visavadar MLA **Gopal Italia** is fast becoming a crowd-puller in Gujarat. Fresh from his bypoll win, he's being asked for more selfies and creating more ripples than the BJP and Congress would like. As a strident Patidar voice, he's caught the eye of political observers, much like Hardik Patel, whose 2017 agitation nearly unseated the BJP that year.

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Rohit Parihar, Avaneesh Mishra, Amitabh Srivastava and Jumana Shah

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

FLU SEASON
PRECISION TESTING IS KEY

Not to cause alarm, but the sniffles have made a comeback—the H3N2 influenza virus is spreading rapidly across parts of India. The uptick is sharpest in Delhi-NCR, where reports say over 60 per cent households have reported flu-like symptoms. The picture can be tricky: fever, fatigue, bodyaches, cough and congestion look identical across influenza subtypes and other respiratory viruses, which risks delayed treatment and unnecessary antibiotics.

That uncertainty matters clinically. Breathlessness or chest pain could mean influenza, RSV (Respiratory syncytial virus, which causes infections in the respiratory tract), parainfluenza, or a bacterial infection—or a co-infection—each demanding different care pathways and infection-control steps. Rapid diagnostics, though, can cut through the fog. "Symptoms and signs alone may not be enough to delineate the cause. Genomic testing can provide precise, pathogen-level identification within a short timeframe," says Mahua Kapoor Dasgupta, director-medical affairs (Infectious Diseases) at HaystackAnalytics. Next-Generation Sequencing, he adds, can detect multiple pathogens from a single sample to guide targeted therapy and appropriate isolation.

Early testing supports timely antivirals, curbs inappropriate antibiotic use, and helps health systems allocate resources better. As Dasgupta puts it, "With rising H3N2 cases, early and accurate diagnosis is indispensable to control the outbreak."